

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

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Finding reasoning paths:

- 1. Persistent sadness with a feeling of hopelessness and difficulty making decisions could indicate chronic depression.
- 2. Recent worsening of symptoms such as suicidal ideations and increased agitation (if mentioned) could point to an emerging major depressive episode or bipolar disorder.
- 3. History of feeling cursed and expecting bad outcomes may indicate a cognitive distortion related to depression or other mental health conditions.
- 4. Difficulty with concentration and energy could suggest a mood disorder like depression or anxiety.

Reasoning Process:

- 1. **Persistent Sadness**: The patient has felt sad for a long time, which suggests a chronic condition such as depression. However, the recent worsening of symptoms (suicidal ideations, agitation) raises concern for an acute episode superimposed on chronic depression.
- 2. **Chronic Feelings of Hopelessness**: This is a common symptom of depression, especially when combined with feelings of being cursed or expecting the worst. These beliefs are often part of the cognitive distortions seen in depression.
- 3. **Difficulty Making Decisions**: This symptom is also characteristic of depression and can be exacerbated by a major depressive episode.
- 4. **Agitation and Suicidal Ideations**: These symptoms are particularly concerning and suggest a potential worsening of mood or psychotic features. Agitation could indicate a psychotic episode in bipolar disorder or depression with psychotic features.
- 5. **Energy and Concentration Issues**: These are typical symptoms of depression and may also contribute to difficulty making decisions.

Conclusion:

The patient's symptoms suggest a combination of chronic depression with recent worsening, possibly indicative of a major depressive episode or bipolar disorder with depression. The chronic sadness, hopelessness, and cognitive distortions are consistent with chronic depression, while the recent worsening, agitation, and suicidal ideations point to a potential acute depressive episode or psychotic features. Given the behavioral statement and recent worsening, the patient may be at risk for worsening of their depression, potentially into a major depressive episode with psychotic features.

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<answer>
The patient is at risk for double depression.
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